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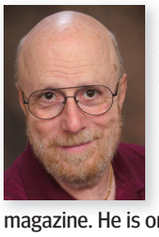
What you need to know about hollowing rigs

Kurt Hertzog shares his thoughts on selecting hollowing rigs

KURT HERTZOG



Kurt is a professional woodturner, demonstrator and teacher and writes for various woodturning and woodworking publications in the United States as well as writing for *Woodturning* magazine. He is on the Pen Makers' Guild Council and is currently president of the American Association of Woodturners (AAW).

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There are many ways to create hollow woodturnings, ranging from the very traditional gouges to some of the more modern implementations of carbide cutters. With that said, what tools are used is driven mostly by the types and depths of hollowing being done. A bowl is a hollow turning as much as a lidded box, it has a different aspect ratio but it is certainly a hollowing. For the most part, hollowing of those types of items is pretty straightforward and is accomplished using the standard woodturning tools. What about far deeper hollowed forms such as vases, urns and the like? They certainly range in size from the 'normal' to very deep. In *WT* 280 – June 2015, we explored hollowing in the generic sense and the basics using hand tools on the more common applications. This month, we'll delve into the realm of hollowing rigs. These are the units that take the tools out of the hands of the turner and provide the mechanical support to control the tool forces. With this support, it allows the user to simply guide the cutting process by manipulating the bar. These are pretty widely varied in their implementation but all share the goals of making deeper hollowing easier and safer. This is especially true when you wish to hollow through a relatively narrow opening. The mechanisation of the various offerings differ somewhat but their goal is to allow for greater reach over the toolrest while restraining the rotational torque that presents itself while cutting.

For those who already own a hollowing system, you might pick up a few tips on setup but we'll mainly focus on the basics for those who haven't yet committed to a system. My goal is to lay out enough of the basics to be helpful in the selection and setup of a hollowing system for newcomers. The cutters and scrapers used in the hollowing rigs are a topic of their own. Nearly every offering in the cutting and scraping arena will fit on or can be adapted to nearly all of the hollowing systems. We'll touch on them this month but they deserve more in-depth coverage of them in a future issue.

Safety

One of the beauties of the hollowing systems available is, by design, they take advantage of good support and leverage control. When hollowing with hand-held turning tools, the user can overreach creating potentially unsafe conditions because of the leverage issues and forces involved. When using any of the hollowing systems you might

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